CineRank - PRD

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OVERVIEW

CineRank is a social movie-ranking app that helps people decide what to watch, alone or together. Users rank movies they've watched head-to-head, and CineRank turns those rankings into a personal taste profile. With one tap, Movie Night uses everyone's taste profiles to suggest a shortlist that fits the whole group.

PROBLEM

People who watch movies at home, whether alone, with a partner or with friends, have no quick way to find a movie that fits their taste, or everyone's taste. The problem is worse at group movie nights, where people propose options, debate them and go back and forth. Often the group ends up watching nothing, or rewatching a movie everyone already knows they like.

Existing options fall short:

Option	What it does	Gaps
Streaming platform recommendations (Netflix, Prime Video, etc.)	Suggests movies from one service based on viewing history	Doesn't know how much you liked a movie unless you rated it; thumbs up or down says little; several people sharing one profile muddy the results
Logging and rating apps (e.g., Letterboxd)	Users log movies and rate them on a star scale	Uses ratings, not rankings, so movies with the same score are hard to tell apart
Swipe apps ("Tinder for movies")	The group swipes until everyone matches on a title	Starts from zero every session, so each decision takes time; doesn't learn taste over time

TARGET USERS

User Group	Persona	Pain Points	What they need from CineRank
The movie tracker	James, 29, analyst in Chicago. Watches 2–3 movies a week, often alone. Keeps a running list of favorites on Letterboxd, follows film conversations online and likes seeing his own watching stats.	1. Ratings blur together: too many movies end up at four stars 2. Generic recommendations: the same popular titles keep coming up 3. No payoff: logging doesn't lead to better picks	1. Head-to-head ranking: separates favorites instead of a pile of four-star movies 2. Taste-based recs: learn from his list, not from what's popular 3. Stats and streaks: tracking has a visible payoff
Couple	Maya and Dev, 28 and 30, living together in Brooklyn. Watch 2–3 movies a week on the couch after work. They share one Netflix account and have overlapping but different tastes: Maya leans toward thrillers, Dev toward comedies.	1. Muddled recs: a shared profile blends both tastes 2. Compromise picks: they settle on something neither is excited about 3. Limited time: scrolling eats into a short weeknight	1. Individual taste profiles: each person's taste stays separate, even with a shared Netflix account 2. Movie Night for 2: picks that fit both, with a reason for each 3. One tap: a shortlist in seconds, so the evening goes to watching
Friend / Family Group	Eesha, 26, and her movie night crew in	1. Too many opinions: lots	1. Group Movie Night: one

	NYC. Eesha hosts a movie night every other weekend for 4–6 people, a mix of college friends and her two cousins. Plans happen in a group chat where everyone suggests something, tastes range from horror to animated movies, and someone has usually already seen the top pick.	of suggestions, no final call 2. Vetoes: already seen or wrong genre, so the debate restarts 3. Unknown tastes: hard to know what everyone actually likes	shortlist balanced across everyone's taste, so there's a final call 2. Filters out what's been seen: fewer vetoes 3, Taste profiles: shows what everyone actually likes

Couples are the primary v0 users; friend groups become primary once group Movie Night ships in v1. Movie trackers are secondary but important: their rankings feed the taste model, which improves recommendations for everyone.

MARKET SIZE

Level	Definition	Calculation	Estimate
TAM	US households that stream video	132.9M US households (IBISWorld) × 91% streaming penetration (Parks Associates)	~120M
SAM	Streaming households where movie choice is a recurring shared decision and someone would use an app to make it	Assumption: 20% of TAM	~24M
SOM	Users CineRank can realistically reach in 3 years	Assumption: 0.5% of SAM	~120K

DEMAND SIGNALS

- US viewers spend about 12 minutes deciding what to watch, up from 10.5 in 2023 (Gracenote / Nielsen, 2025).
- 21% of streaming users give up and do something else when they can't find what to watch (Nielsen).
- 52% of Americans now go to friends' homes for dedicated viewing sessions, up 15% in a year (Harris Poll / Tubi, 2026).
- Letterboxd grew from 1.7M users in 2020 to over 30M members by July 2026, showing demand for social movie apps (Wikipedia).

PROPOSED SOLUTION

CineRank combines a ranking app, similar to Beli for restaurants, with an AI matchmaker for movie night.

VALUE PROPS

1. Rankings, not ratings: instead of giving stars, users compare a new movie against ones they've already ranked. Each comparison places it more precisely, building a ranked list that separates favorites from movies that were just "good."
2. One-tap Movie Night: choose who's watching, tap once, and get 3–5 movies that fit everyone, each with a short reason.
3. Social discovery: follow friends, see how closely your tastes match, and get picks from people who rank like you.

HOW RANKING WORKS

When a user adds a movie, CineRank asks a few "which did you like more?" questions against movies already on their list. It narrows down the position with each answer, so even a 100-movie list takes only about 7 comparisons. The final position gives the movie a score, and the rankings and any comments feed the taste profile.

CORE LOOP

Watch → rank → taste profile improves → better Movie Night picks → watch more

Every Movie Night ends with a prompt to rank what you watched, so each session makes the next one better.

GOALS AND NON-GOALS

GOALS

1. Decide fast: one tap from "find a movie" to a shortlist of 3–5 options for two or more people.
2. Learn taste from rankings: recommendations improve with every comparison and comment.
3. Make tracking fun: ranking, streaks and top-5 lists people want to come back to.
4. Discover through friends: surface movies loved by people with similar taste.

NON-GOALS

1. TV shows.
2. Streaming playback or synced watch parties.
3. A review site (comments feed the taste profile; they aren't a destination).
4. Monetization (revisit once retention is proven).

REQUIREMENTS

P0 = needed for v0 · P1 = important for a great experience · P2 = nice to have.

RANKING AND TRACKING

Priority	Requirement
P0	Search for a watched movie and add it to watched list
P0	Rank a new movie through head-to-head comparisons, placing it in as few comparisons as possible (target: about $\log_2$ of list size)
P0	View a personal ranked list with derived scores
P0	Add a comment to any ranked movie
P0	Re-rank or remove a movie
P1	Watch log with dates and activity streaks

P1	Top 5 shown on profile
P1	Photo posts on watched movies
P2	Import watch history from a CSV to beat cold start

WATCHLIST

Priority	Requirement
P0	Save a movie to the watchlist from search, recommendations or a friend's profile
P1	Movie Night favors titles already on members' watchlists

MOVIE NIGHT

Priority	Requirement
P0	Movie Night for 2: pick a friend, tap once, get 3–5 options with reasoning for each
P0	Mark the chosen movie as watched, then prompt everyone to rank it
P0	Exclude movies anyone in the group has already seen
P1	Movie Night for 3+, balancing every member's taste profile
P1	Filters for runtime, genre and where it's streaming
P1	Add Recommended Movie to Watchlist
P2	Guest link so a friend without an account can join

AI TASTE PROFILE + REC

Priority	Requirement
P0	LLM-generated taste profile built from rankings and comments, viewable by the user
P0	Personal recommendations from the taste profile
P1	Taste profile refreshes after a set number of new rankings
P1	"Not interested" and "already seen" feedback on recommendations
P2	User picks a mood; recommendations adjust

SOCIAL

Priority	Requirement
P0	Public Profiles
P0	Follow Friends
P0	Taste-match score with friends, plus picks from friends with similar taste
P1	Activity feed of friends' rankings with reactions and interactions
P2	Opt-in notifications with movie ideas (for example, a weekend suggestion)

PLATFORM

Priority	Requirement
P0	Event tracking for the funnel and every metric below
P0	Account deletion and data export

SUCCESS METRICS

NORTH STAR

- Movie Night Conversion: share of Movie Night sessions where the group watches a suggested movie and at least one person ranks it afterward. It shows the pick was good enough to watch, and the ranking feeds data back into the loop. Target: 60%+.

INPUT METRICS

- Weekly Active Rankers: Users who rank at least one movie in a week.
- Movie Night sessions per week: Number of Movie Night sessions started per week.
- Rankings before a good recommendation: Rankings a new user makes before their first watched recommendation.
- Time to decide: seconds from tapping “find a movie” to choosing one.
- Invites per Movie Night: New users invited through a session.

GUARDRAILS

- Recommendation dismiss rate does not rise as notifications grow.
- Notification opt-out rate.
- LLM cost per active user.
- Week-4 retention does not fall as features ship.

RISKS, OPEN QUESTIONS, RELEASE PLAN

RISKS

Risk	Mitigation
Cold start: new users have too few rankings for good picks	Onboarding quick-rank of 10 popular movies; CSV import
Ranking fatigue: comparisons start to feel like a chore	Cap comparisons per movie; allow "can't decide"
Groups with very different tastes get bland picks	Show the reason behind each pick; allow reroll and filters

Movie Night needs friends on the app	Invite link from every session; guest mode (P2)
LLM cost and latency grow with users	Cache taste profiles; refresh only after new rankings
Movie metadata API terms limit use	Review provider terms and attribution before scaling

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How much should comments count compared with rankings in the taste profile?
- Which data source covers where a movie is streaming?
- Mobile app or responsive web first?
- What would monetization look like once retention is proven?

RELEASE PLAN

Now (v0): all P0s. Ranking, taste profiles, initial social features, recommendations and Movie Night for 2.

Next (v1): all P1s. Group Movie Night, filters, recommendation feedback and detailed activity feed.

Later (v2): all P2s. CSV import, guest links, notifications and mood-based recommendations.